

The seasons

Earth spins as it orbits the Sun. However, it doesn't spin in an upright position, but on an axis tilted 23.5 degrees from the vertical. It is this tilt that causes the seasons. Over a year, different parts of Earth will be closer to or farther away from the Sun and will receive more or less sunlight, giving rise to summers and winters, and wet and dry seasons in the tropics.

ORBITING EARTH

In June, Earth's northern half faces the Sun. It enjoys long, warm summer days when the Sun rises high in the sky. Meanwhile, the southern half has short, cold winter days when the Sun stays low. In December, the southern half faces the Sun, so it is summer there, but winter in the north. The polar regions have 24-hour daylight in summer and permanent darkness in winter.

THROUGH THE YEAR

In the zone between the tropics and the polar regions, each year consists of spring, summer, autumn, and winter seasons. In spring, trees start growing and often sprout new leaves. They keep growing all summer, then slow down in autumn. In the chill of winter, many plants lie dormant, waiting for spring.



Spring



Summer



Autumn



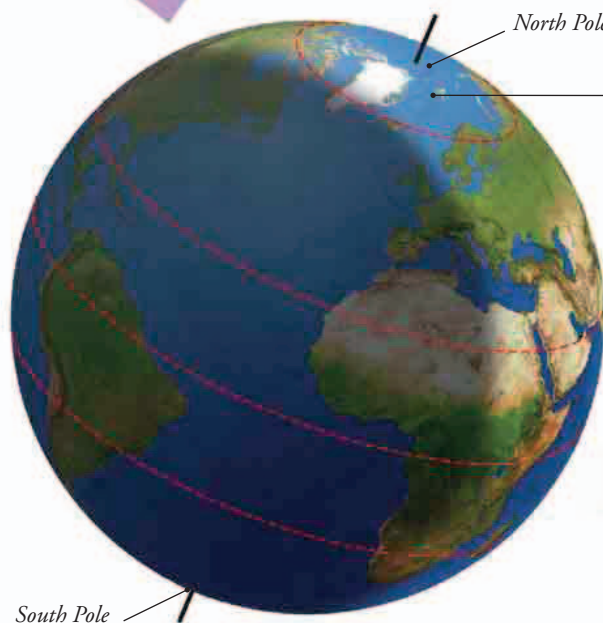
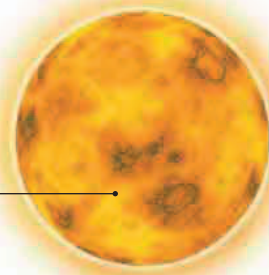
Winter



▲ MARCH

Days are the same length in both the north (where it is spring) and the south (where it is autumn).

Sun



North Pole

The Arctic enjoys 24-hour daylight in summer

◀ JUNE

At this point in Earth's orbit, the north is facing the Sun, so it receives more sunlight than the south and enjoys more hours of daylight.

South Pole